

Diplomacy **S.M. KRISHNA**

In the HOT SEAT

The veteran politician hits the ground running as diplomatic challenges demand bold new initiatives



BANDEEP SINGH

| By Saurabh Shukla |

Even before congratulatory bouquets have dried in the five-star hotel room where the new Foreign Minister S.M. Krishna, is currently lodged, he is already immersed in diplomatic crises. The hotlines haven't stopped ringing as news of yet another bomb blast came in from Lahore in Pakistan. The report from the Indian mission in Pakistan painted a gloomy picture about the security situation in the nuclear-armed neighbour. Krishna, 77, may be an accomplished tennis player but the former Karnataka chief minister and professor of international law will require all his skills to counter the diplomatic smashes heading his way, fuelled by instability in Pakistan.

The parachute candidate seems to have hit the ground running, having already offered a proposal to the Asif Ali Zardari Government before India can even think about resuming the dialogue with Pakistan. In an exclusive interview to *INDIA TODAY* (see box), Krishna said, "We will work on a zero-tolerance policy on terrorism from Pakistan. We condemn all terrorist acts, whether they happen in Lahore,

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S.M. Krishna, the veteran politician, is now India's top diplomat. Already engulfed by the crisis in Pakistan and turbulence in the neighbourhood, he sat down with Senior Editor SAURABH SHUKLA for an exclusive interview. Excerpts.

Q. There was a terror attack in Lahore. Do you think the Frankenstein of terror is coming back to haunt Pakistan?

A. Whether it happens in Lahore or London or Mumbai, India condemns all acts of terrorism. Pakistan is becoming vulnerable to terrorist attacks.